Endless Flight

Erich Honecker celebrated May Day 1958 in Copenhagen, where he was applauded after announcing ‘those responsible for crimes against Denmark in the Second World War had been brought to account in the GDR’. An item transmitted by ADN, added that he also charged ‘West German militarists’ with continuing to work against normalisation of relations between the GDR and Denmark.1

This tirade against Bonn was delivered under the shadow of the FRG’s ‘economic miracle’ or ‘Wirtschaftswunder’, which continued to impress the world and surprise even Germans themselves. This extraordinary prosperity – where possibility had no bounds – saw car production increase by 100,000 compared to 1956, while the national income shot up by 10 per cent. Furthermore, exports recorded a 16 per cent increase and shipping tonnage rose by 12 per cent. The sensational recovery was attributed, in part, to Conrad Adenauer, who was voted into office again in 1957.

While Western media celebrated Wirtschaftswunder, it followed the contrasting situation in the GDR where, in a clear attempt to tame spiralling inflation, the government called in all existing GDR bank note currency and replaced it (without devaluation) with a new issue on a strictly rationed basis. This made it almost impossible for banknotes held by people living abroad to be exchanged.2 To make matters worse, the loss of GDR manpower to the West continued despite new laws authorising prison sentences for those attempting to leave without permission.

During this period, Honecker’s security services ensured the noose around the GDR was strengthened. A permit was needed to enter a four-mile zone close to the national border, where frontier police surveyed the zone from dug-outs and watchtowers. Three parallel barbed-wire fences ran along parts of the frontier, a foretaste of Berlin’s future.